

Legible in Time (250 words)

Months after taking Forensics, I kept reading *HeraldNet* archives. There was something unsettling about cases so close to home, in places I passed without thinking.

In 1984, Judy Weaver was strangled, bound with a telephone cord, and left in a room set ablaze. Detectives considered suspects but found no physical evidence strong enough, so the case went dormant.

Once marked cold, there was no legal requirement to revisit a case, leaving its future to discretion.

Forty years later, retired detective Steve Brenneman reopened it after noticing that the killing resembled the methods of Mitchell Gaff, a convicted rapist. The ligature was reexamined using touch DNA extraction, technology that didn't exist when the evidence was collected, and run through CODIS. Even after a match, investigators needed probable cause. So instead of seeking a warrant, they went undercover as "gum surveyors" to collect Gaff's saliva. The DNA matched.

Weaver's case underscored how fragile the path to truth can be. The ligature was preserved without knowing what it might reveal. The case was reopened because an investigator recognized a pattern. Without that foresight or intuition, her case could still be cold.

I keep reading these cases because they force me to think about how much truth our systems leave to luck. Evidence can exist for decades without being legible, and justice can hinge on whether someone happens to look twice. I want to know how we can design systems that anticipate what they can't yet see, ensuring truths become legible in time.